

What is Language Development?

McEwan defines the “meaning pieces” of reading as language, knowledge, and cognitive strategies. She describes the facets of oral language as “(a) the meanings of words (lexicon), (b) how words are put together in utterances to convey a message (semantics and syntax), and (c) how discourse, or conversational interactions of various kinds, is carried out” (2002, p. 68). Consider how much of the code most children have absorbed by the time they enter school. They hear and understand the meaning of thousands of words, although many of them on a superficial level. They use many of those words in appropriate contexts (and, sometimes, in not so appropriate contexts). They speak in increasingly complex phrases and sentences, at first to express their needs and feelings and gradually to interact with adults and their peers.

Capute, Shapiro, and Palmer (1986), in their *Clinical Linguistic and Auditory Milestone Scale*, include these benchmarks for a 3-year-old: uses pronouns discriminately, uses plurals, forms 3-word sentences, and has a 250-word vocabulary. They will understand a great many more words spoken to them, since young children are more advanced in receptive (hearing) language than in expressive (speaking) language. Children at a very early age learn the basics of their native language, leading some researchers to have believed that language development is essentially complete at this young age (Ely, 2005). Language development is the keystone for the development of reading, writing, and thinking skills. Especially in the early years, when young minds are ripe for language learning, it should be a major focus in curriculum.

While all preschoolers have moved along the continuum of language development, some have progressed much further and much faster than others. What determines these different rates of language acquisition? A great deal depends upon the richness of children’s literacy environments and supports. Factors that have an impact on language development include the following:

- The amount and nature of the language parents or caregivers use with children
- Feedback adults provide as children experiment with language
- Time spent reading to children and discussing books with them
- Opportunities children have to interact with others in social situations

The learning and literacy achievement gap already exists when children enter school. Preschool teachers know that many students are nowhere near attaining the average cited in the Capute scale. Other research indicates that the average 4-year-old in a low-income family might have had 13 million fewer words of cumulative experience than their middle-class peers have had (Hart & Risley, 1995). Limited listening and speaking vocabularies affect what children are able to do as emergent readers and writers. Because oral language provides the underpinnings for developing literacy skills, teachers must make addressing oral language needs a priority.

The first thing teachers should do is assess where their students are in terms of vocabulary, usage (grammar and sentence structure), communication, and other skills such as attending to and comprehending read-alouds. These skills will not develop in a smooth, linear sequence. Children may make progress in one area and lag behind in another, though many of the skills may develop simultaneously. Oral language, including vocabulary, sentence structure, grammar, and discourse, should be assessed in the enrollment process or as soon as possible after children begin school.

Language assessments may be informal with the teacher listening, observing, and documenting speech and listening behaviors. Pinnell (1985) has formulated a system of categorizing language functions originally developed by Halliday (as cited in Pinnell, 1985). The categories still provide a useful

framework for teacher observation. The seven categories are instrumental language (expressing wants, needs), regulatory language (controlling others' behavior), interaction language (establishing and defining social relationships), personal language (expressing individuality), imaginative language, heuristic language (exploring the environment, investigating), and informative language. According to Pinnell (1985), two kinds of assessment can be made by observing a child's language:

1. An assessment of an individual child's competence by looking at the extent to which he or she uses the various functions of language and how effectively.
2. An assessment of the language environment by determining which functions occurred and where and which functions are being neglected.

More formal assessments, such as subtests of the ITBS (*Iowa Test of basic Skills*), the PPVT (*Peabody Picture Vocabulary Test, Third Edition*), or BINL (*Basic Inventory of natural Language*), may be employed to establish a baseline and/or to document growth over time, but formal assessments are not necessary to identify youngsters who need early intervention. Teachers will likely know them by the end of the first day of school. Though some students may just need time to warm up to the school environment, teachers will spot those who articulate poorly, whose word knowledge is limited, and whose grammar and sentence structure is delayed (e.g., "Me like" rather than "I like"). They are the students who will need all that teachers provide to move their more accomplished peers along the language development continuum—and more.

Poor articulators may have phonological and phonemic awareness problems. They should be referred for screening by the school nurse and speech therapist as soon as possible. Meanwhile, in the classroom the teacher should consistently provide very clear and distinct modeling of pronunciations, calling attention to what she is doing with her lips, tongue, breath, and sound box. (Therapists have a repertoire of strategies to share.)

All students need multiple opportunities daily for hearing texts read aloud, discussing them, and retelling. These texts should represent many genres and should definitely include many works of nonfiction. Reading aloud helps all students to add to their listening and speaking vocabularies, to extend the levels of sophistication of their grammar and sentence structure, to develop their sense of text structures, and to develop and use other comprehension strategies. In the best of situations, those experiences of listening, discussing, and retelling are part of routines at home as well. Teachers should do all they can to enlist parents as partners to read with and to children at home.

When reading aloud does not happen regularly in the home, the gap widens. Teachers need to provide opportunities for those children to hear more texts read aloud, especially nonfiction. (vicarious experiences cannot make up for all the disadvantaged students have missed, but they can help.) Enlisting volunteers to read to them one-on-one or in small groups or using books on tape are two possible strategies. Some of the texts can be classics such as *Goodnight Moon*, *Caps for Sale*, *The Napping House*, along with nursery rhymes and fairy tales that some of these children may never have heard but that are old friends to their peers, and other texts that provide background for curricular studies.

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